

Ch 4 — Political Parties

Functions · Party Systems · National & State Parties · Challenges · Reforms

1. WHAT IS A POLITICAL PARTY?

"A political party is a group of people who come together to contest elections and hold power in the government."
— **Edmund Burke** defined a party as "a body of men united for promoting by their joint endeavours the national interest upon some particular principle in which they are all agreed."

Core Characteristics

- Seeks to **win elections** and control the government.
- Represents a particular **section of society** or a set of values.
- Puts forward **policies and programmes** for the welfare of society.
- Tries to **persuade people** that its policies are better than those of rivals.
- Has a long-term **vision** for society and the country.

Three Essential Components

1. Leaders

- Run for elections, make decisions, shape policy.
- Often the public face of the party.

2. Active Members

- Work at grass-roots level.
- Campaign, recruit, mobilise voters.

3. Followers / Supporters

- Ordinary citizens who vote for the party and identify with its ideology.
- Much larger in number than active members.

2. FUNCTIONS OF POLITICAL PARTIES (7)

1. **Contest Elections:** Parties put up candidates; in most democracies, candidates are nominated by parties, not individuals.
2. **Put forward Policies & Programmes:** Each party stands for a particular ideology; voters choose among competing agendas.
3. **Making Laws:** Parties influence law-making — most bills are passed along party lines in the legislature.
4. **Form Governments:** The party (or alliance) winning a majority forms the government; leaders of the winning party become ministers.
5. **Role of Opposition:** Parties that lose elections sit in opposition, criticise the government and keep it accountable.
6. **Shape Public Opinion:** Parties raise issues, debate problems, and mobilise public support through campaigns and media.
7. **Access to Government Machinery:** Parties provide citizens a link to government — they articulate demands and relay public needs to the state.

3. WHY DO WE NEED POLITICAL PARTIES?

Without political parties, several problems arise:

- **No Policy Promises:** Candidates would represent only their locality; no national vision or programme.
- **No Accountability:** With no organisation behind a leader, voters cannot hold anyone responsible for government's performance.
- **Fragmentation:** Hundreds of independent representatives could not coordinate; stable governments would be impossible.
- **Lack of Continuity:** A single individual would find it impossible to maintain policy consistency across terms.
- **Difficulty in Governance:** Elected governments need to pass laws, raise taxes, run services — all requiring organised majorities.

Conclusion: Parties are indispensable for representative democracy to function at scale.

4. PARTY SYSTEMS

System	Description	Examples
One-Party System	Only one party is allowed to govern; other parties are banned. Not considered truly democratic.	China, North Korea, Cuba
Two-Party System	Two major parties dominate; power alternates between them. Smaller parties exist but rarely win national power.	USA (Republican & Democrat), UK (Conservative & Labour)
Multi-Party System	Multiple parties compete; no single party usually wins an overall majority — leads to coalition governments.	India, France, Germany

Why India has a Multi-Party System

- India's enormous **social, cultural, linguistic, and religious diversity** cannot be captured by just two parties.
- Different regions have distinct interests — local and regional parties represent them effectively.
- The Constitution guarantees freedom of association — no bar on forming new parties.

Major Alliance Groups in India

NDA (National Democratic Alliance)

- Led by BJP.
- Centre-right coalition; formed government 1999–2004, 2014–present.

UPA (United Progressive Alliance)

- Led by INC (Congress).
- Centre-left coalition; in power 2004–2014.

I.N.D.I.A (Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance)

Multi-party opposition alliance formed in 2023 to contest NDA; includes INC, AAP, TMC, DMK, and others.

5. NATIONAL AND STATE PARTIES

ECI Recognition Criteria

The Election Commission of India (ECI) grants "Recognised Party" status based on vote share or seats won. A party is **National** if it achieves recognition in at least **four or more states** or gets **6% votes** in four states plus 4 Lok Sabha seats.

Six National Parties (as per latest recognition)

Indian National Congress (INC) 1885

India's oldest party · Centre-left · Secular · Led independence movement · Key leader: Sonia Gandhi / Rahul Gandhi

Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) 1980

Centre-right · Hindu nationalist · Currently in power · Key leaders: Narendra Modi, Amit Shah

Communist Party of India (Marxist) — CPI-M 1964

Left · Marxist-Leninist ideology · Strong in Kerala and West Bengal · Key leader: Sitaram Yechury

Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) 1984

Dalit-centric · Founded by Kanshi Ram · Led by Mayawati · Strong in UP

Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) 2012

Anti-corruption · Founded by Arvind Kejriwal · Governs Delhi and Punjab · Youngest national party

National People's Party (NPP) 2013

North-East India focus · P.A. Sangma founded · Recognised as national party

Major State Parties (examples)

- **DMK** — Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (Tamil Nadu)
- **TMC** — Trinamool Congress (West Bengal)
- **Shiv Sena** — Maharashtra
- **JD(U)** — Janata Dal (United) (Bihar)

6. CHALLENGES TO POLITICAL PARTIES (4 KEY CHALLENGES)

1. Lack of Internal Democracy

Power is concentrated among a few top leaders. Ordinary members have little say in candidate selection or policy decisions. Party elections are rarely held.

2. Dynastic Succession

Leadership positions are passed within the founder's family. Outsiders rarely get to the top. This is especially common in India (e.g., Gandhi family in INC).

3. Growing Role of Money and Muscle Power

Candidates with criminal records or enormous wealth win nominations. Elections are increasingly expensive, making parties dependent on big donors and corrupt sources.

4. No Meaningful Choice

On many issues, all major parties hold similar positions — voters feel there is no real difference between parties. Reduces quality of democratic choice.

7. REFORMS TO POLITICAL PARTIES

A. Already Implemented

- **Anti-Defection Law (1985 — 52nd Amendment):** An elected member who changes party loses the parliamentary/assembly seat. Prevents arbitrary switching; but also reduces dissent within the party.
- **Affidavit Requirement (2003 — Supreme Court order):** Candidates must declare criminal record, assets, and educational qualifications. Enables informed voting.
- **ECI Orders on party elections and internal democracy:** The Commission has directed parties to hold internal elections, file accounts, etc.

B. Suggested Reforms

- **Regulate party internals by law:** Require open membership, transparent candidate selection, audited finances.
- **Women's Quota (33%):** Reserve one-third of seats/nominations for women (Women's Reservation Bill introduced several times but not yet fully enacted for elections).
- **State Funding of Elections:** Government provides campaign funds to reduce dependence on corrupt money.
- **Decriminalisation:** Bar candidates with serious criminal charges from contesting elections.
- **Electoral System Change:** Shift from First-Past-the-Post (FPTP) to Proportional Representation (PR) to ensure every vote counts.

C. Citizens' Role

- Join parties and participate actively — pressure from inside creates genuine internal democracy.
- Demand transparency: use RTI, support investigative journalism.
- Support civil society organisations that put pressure on parties to reform.
- Vote thoughtfully — reject candidates with criminal records; study candidate affidavits.